

Introduction to cURL from the command line

[Video](#) about this material.

According to [Wikipedia](#):

***cURL** (pronounced like "curl",^[7] /kɜːrl/) is a [free and open source](#) computer program for transferring data to and from [Internet](#) servers. It can download a [URL](#) from a [web server](#) over [HTTP](#), and supports a variety of other [network protocols](#), [URI](#) schemes, multiple versions of [HTTP](#), and [proxying](#). The project consists of both a [library](#) ([libcurl](#)) and [command-line tool](#) ([curl](#)), which have been widely ported to different [computing platforms](#).*

It was created by [Daniel Stenberg](#), who is still the lead developer of the project.

The command line cURL tool is part of Windows OS distributions since Windows 10, and is usually a part of most Linux and Mac OS distributions as well. In these activities you will get to try out command line cURL.

1. Make sure curl is installed:

In your Linux or Mac terminal window:

```
curl -V
```

Is curl installed? If so, what version are you using?

Note if that curl is not installed, you should install it. On a Mac OS you will first need to [install homebrew](#) or some other package manager. After you install homebrew, you can install curl with:

```
brew install curl
```

On most Debian/Ubuntu Linux distributions you can install curl with:

```
sudo apt-get install curl
```

2. Use curl from the command line.

Try out the following command:

```
curl https://example.com
```

You might recognize the resulting text as html. If you are using a system in which you can open up a browser window, try doing the following command:

```
curl https://example.com > example.html
```

In this command we are using the output redirection symbol > to redirect the output of the command to a file named example.html. This is a useful thing to do when we'd like to examine the output further or do something else with it.

If you now double click on this file, it should open up in an internet browser (the .html extension indicates that the file is an html file that a browser can read) and you will be able to see the webpage just as if you had gone to the <https://example.com> address.

3. curl can also be used to return data in JSON form. Try:

```
curl https://jsonplaceholder.typicode.com/posts
```

Hopefully, you recognize this as being in the [JSON](#) format. This particular website is used as a sandbox for experimenting with Application Programming Interfaces (APIs), which are the rules and specifications that allow different software systems to communicate and interact with each other.

What are the keys in this JSON record?

4. You can make the output look a little nicer by doing the following:

```
curl https://jsonplaceholder.typicode.com/posts | jq
```

What this does is take the output of the curl command and gives it as input to the jq command, which is a lightweight, command line JSON processor. In this case it is converting the plain text to a "pretty-print". The "|" character is called "pipe" and it sends the output of the command on the left to be the input to the command on the right. So in this case, the output of the curl command is fed to the jq command

What does pretty-print mean?

5. Ask your favorite AI tool to teach you more about jq or using curl from the command line and try out some of the suggestions. Spend 10 minutes learning more about this topic. List 3 things that you learned here.

TURN IN: The answers to the questions in each section.